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The Oval Agenda

- **ON TERRORISM:** May push for stronger action against countries fomenting terrorism, has warned Pakistan he may attack terror camps if it fails to act. This will help India too.
- **ON NUCLEAR ISSUE:** Will implement the Indo-US nuclear deal, may press for binding agreements like CTBT and FMCT.
- **ON KASHMIR:** Would want an early resolution, may appoint a special envoy but unlikely to force a solution.
- **ON VISA REGIME:** Expected to increase H1-B visas that may benefit Indian professionals.
- **ON DEFENCE CO-OPERATION:** Defence exchanges may grow and he is likely to seek Indian co-operation to stabilise Afghanistan.

MANMOHAN AND OBAMA NEED TO BUILD A PERSONAL CHEMISTRY

new democratic regime will be good for India, "Over two-thirds of the India caucus members in the US Congress are from the Democratic Party and the relationship will naturally grow. They may have a stronger policy on nuclear non-proliferation and push for binding treaties but it wouldn't be directed at India alone," feels Naresh Chandra, former ambassador to the US. On the critical climate change issue, experts believe India may see some greater pressure to cut a deal before the Copenhagen conference on climate change in 2009. During the campaign, Obama-Biden also promised to enter into a dialogue with India and China with regard to reducing emission lev-

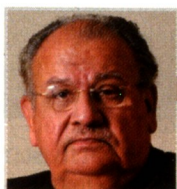
els. "Multilateral negotiations on climate change will certainly get a boost, but knowing his rational set of advisers I don't think he would only put pressure on the developing world, without any concessions from the developed world," says R.K. Pachauri, chairman of the UN's Inter-Governmental Panel on Climate Change.

Obama has already said it is imperative that Washington and Delhi work together to combat common threats of the 21st century, like terrorism. Shedding the unilateralist approach of Bush will win him greater friends in India on this count. Besides, if he is serious about getting rid of terror swamps wherever they exist, this may actually be the first bold step towards hitting at the epicentre of terrorism. While some discomfort was

felt about his statement about an early resolution of the Kashmir issue, and there is a talk of Bill Clinton being appointed as a special envoy on Kashmir, it is unlikely that he would try to force a solution on India in a transformed strategic scenario. Early pointers indicate that on issues like terrorism, Pakistan and Afghanistan, Obama is willing to experiment with new ideas. The Indian leadership would also need to take the cue to sensitise him about the challenges in the region which endanger global security and to persuade him to take a zero-tolerance approach on terrorism.

In his larger foreign policy priorities, Obama may focus his energies on Afghanistan which is in consonance with what India has been trying to do through its goodwill diplomacy.

Even though much will depend on who will man his key cabinet posts, there may be some redlines on issues such as Security Council expansion, and adhering to a fissile material cut-off treaty (FMCT). The honeymoon phase of bilateral relationship may have begun under a Republican administration, where the foundations of a truly strategic relationship were laid, but under Obama it is expected to bloom further. ■



NARESH CHANDRA, *Former Indian Ambassador to US*

“He may press for treaties like CTBT and FMCT but that wouldn't be directed at India.”



R.K. PACHAURI, *Chairman, IPCC*

“Climate change talks will get a boost, and he may be willing to address India's concerns.”